all the commerce of Asia, and would shake to the centre of India, the enormous commercial superiority of the dominators of the sea.[67]

This was the very stuff from which Russophobia was made, and it is not hard to see why de Lacy Evans' work was to have a profound influence on policy-makers in London. Importantly, de Lacy Evans believed that Russia would not actually attempt to conquer India in its entirety, but would instead seek to destabilise British rule there.

This view would be shared by a young Curzon, travelling through Central Asia almost sixty years later to survey the recently constructed Transcaspian railway (Krasnovodsk–Ashkhabad–Merv–Bukhara). Recording his thoughts in Russia in Central Asia and the Anglo-Russian Question (first published in 1889) Curzon believed that the full significance of the railway had been overlooked in London. He pointed out how the railway line had made this previously difficult terrain now relatively easy to traverse, enabling Russia to move its troops quicker than ever through Central Asia and up to India's borders. Yet even then, Curzon still believed that no Russian was foolish enough to attempt to invade India completely. Instead, it was probable Russia would try an attack on the Raj in order to distract Britain: 'To keep England quiet in Europe by keeping her employed in Asia, that, briefly put, is the sum and substance of Russian policy.'[68]

Opinion on the relative likelihood of a Russian invasion of India appeared to ebb and flow at various points throughout the nineteenth and twentieth centuries, and of course varied from person to person.[69] For example, in 1884 Sir Charles MacGregor calculated just how many Russian troops could be mustered against the Raj, an exercise designed to highlight the inadequate numbers of Britain's troops in India should its northerly neighbour chose to attack.[70] Even by 1905, Russia's intentions were still being discussed, with Lord Kitchener, commander-in-chief of the Indian army, claiming that the main danger facing India was 'the menacing advance of Russia towards our frontiers'. For Kitchener, the likelihood of invasion was real enough to warrant extensive expansion of the Indian army.[71]